

**Optimistic start:** Aman Sehrawat became the first Indian wrestler to win a medal in 2024 as he bagged the top honour at the Zagreb Open. The Under-23 world champion beat China's Zou Wanhao for the title in the 57kg category. UNITED WORLD WRESTLING



category at a pre-Olympic World Championship might be considered the favourite to travel to the Games, Antim might not have as smooth a path to Paris.

According to the rules laid out by the (now suspended) WFI, only a gold or silver medallist at the World Championship can travel directly to the Olympic Games.

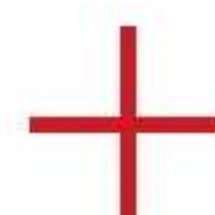
Antim now faces a selection trial to secure her spot, and with seasoned wrestler Vinesh also making a comeback after a year of absence due to knee surgery, the competition for an Olympic berth promises to be intense, adding a layer of complexity to India's wrestling preparations for Paris. Vinesh has returned to training. Although she is unlikely to be anywhere near her best, she has a wealth of experience and has beaten Antim on the two occasions they have wrestled previously. But Vinesh seems to have been bogged down by the demanding year-long protest. It's not just her; Sakshi, the 2016 Olympic hero, has already

announced her retirement.

At the Asian Games, Bajrang lost in the semis and was beaten 10-0 in the bronze medal playoff. He appears to be a mere shadow of his former self, and there are doubts as to whether he will even make it past the selection trials for the Indians, let alone earn an Olympic quota in the two qualifying tournaments (the Asian Olympic qualification tournament in April and the World Qualification tournament in May).

It isn't just the protesting wrestlers who are struggling. Anshu Malik, who had a breakout season in 2021 when she qualified for the Olympics as a 19-year-old and then won silver in the women's 57kg category at the world championships, is going through a poor run of form. At the selection trials to pick the team for the 2023 World Championships, Anshu lost in the very first round.

Deepak Punia, who narrowly lost out in his bronze medal match in Tokyo, is also nowhere close to the form that saw him win gold at the junior worlds, followed by a silver at



### Highlights of 2023 Men

Aman Sehrawat won gold in the men's **57kg** category at the **2023** Asian Championships

### Women

Antim Panghal won bronze in the women's **53kg** category at the **2023** Wrestling World Championships in Belgrade

### Juniors

Antim Panghal won gold in the women's **53kg** category at the **2023** Junior World championships in Amman, becoming the first Indian to win consecutive gold medals at the junior worlds

### U-23

Reetika Hooda became the first Indian woman to win gold at the **U-23** World Championships when she finished top of the podium in the women's **76kg** category at the **U-23** Worlds in Tirana, Albania